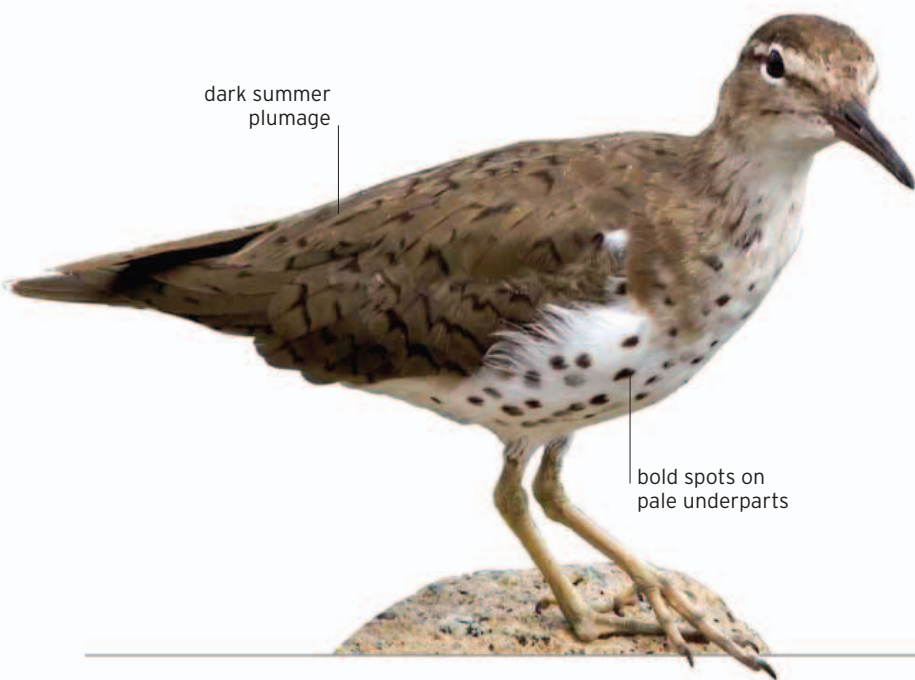


dark summer
plumagebold spots on
pale underparts

Spotted sandpiper

Actitis macularia

- ↔ 7–8 in (18–20 cm)
- 📍 North, Central, and South America
- ⊗ Common

Breeding across most of North America and migrating to the tropics in winter, this small, active, white and brown wader is common in a wide variety of habitats ranging from city parks to the Arctic tundra—although it is nearly always near water. As with some other waders, the female courts the male with quivering wings and fanned tail, and may mate with several different males; each male then incubates a clutch of eggs.

Herring gull

Larus argentatus

- ↔ 22–26 in (55–67 cm)
- 📍 North and Central America, Europe, NE. and E. Asia
- ⊗ Common

Few seabirds are as familiar as the herring gull—a large, gray and white bird with a loud bugling call that is one of the emblematic sounds of northern shores. Highly adaptable, it will eat almost anything and has become an expert at surviving on refuse scavenged from city streets and garbage dumps. This allows it to forage well inland, and it often nests on rooftops in coastal towns.

Sooty tern

Onychoprion fuscatus

- ↔ 14–18 in (35–45 cm)
- 📍 Worldwide, in tropical seas
- ⊗ Common

Mainly black above and white below, with a long, forked tail, this tropical tern is one of the world's most abundant seabirds. It lives out on the open ocean in large flocks, snatching small prey from the surface rather than plunge-diving like a typical tern. It remains at sea for most of the year, returning to remote islands to breed in noisy colonies that may have more than a million pairs.

Guillemot

Uria aalge

- ↔ 16–17 in (41–43 cm)
- 📍 North Atlantic, North Pacific
- ⊗ Common

One of the auks—northern counterparts of the penguins—this neat, black-and-white seabird uses its short wings for swimming underwater in pursuit of fish and other prey. It breeds in large colonies on coastal cliffs, each pair incubating their single egg on a narrow ledge of bare rock. The egg has a conical form, so it rolls in a circle if dislodged rather than falling off the ledge. The young

leave the cliff nest site when they are just three weeks old, leaping into the sea on half-fledged wings.

Other species

- African jacana
Actophilornis africanus » p224
- African skimmer
Rynchops flavirostris » p226
- Antarctic tern
Sterna vittata » p369
- Atlantic puffin
Fratercula arctica » p138–39
- Pied avocet
Recurvirostra avosetta » p149

dark brown
to black headdark rump
with narrow
white sides

Pigeons

Order Columbiformes

Rock dove

Columba livia

- ↔ 12–14 in (30–36 cm)
- 📍 North, Central and South America, Africa, Europe, Asia, Australia
- ⊗ Common

Also known as the rock pigeon, this species is the wild ancestor of the common feral pigeon, found in cities worldwide. In its wild form, it is largely gray, with iridescent feathers on its neck and upper breast. The wild birds feed

on seeds and nest on sea cliffs and in river gorges—a habit that was readily adaptable to urban landscapes, where their feral counterparts nest on buildings.

black bars
on wings

Common wood pigeon

Columba palumbus

- ↔ 16–18 in (41–45 cm)
- 📍 Europe, NW. Africa, W. and C. Asia
- ⊗ Common

The throaty, cooing calls of the wood pigeon are a familiar feature of the countryside throughout most of its wide range. Originally a woodland bird, it has adapted so well to feeding on farmland that it has become a pest, with big flocks raiding fields for the seeds of cereals and other crops. Males perform distinctive gliding, wing-clapping displays, which are sometimes echoed by females.

Southern crowned pigeon

Goura scheepmakeri

- ↔ 26–29 in (66–74 cm)
- 📍 S. New Guinea
- ⊗ Vulnerable

This big, blue and maroon tropical pigeon owes its name to its flamboyant crest of lacy blue-gray feathers. It feeds on the ground in small groups, searching the forest floor for seeds, fallen fruit, and small animals. It retires to a roost in the branches during the hottest part of the day and nests high in a tree. Like other pigeons—and flamingos—it feeds its young on “milk” secreted from its crop.